



EVERYBODY HAS THEIR REASONS

THE RULES OF THE GAME / 1939

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Comedy of manners

DIRECTOR

Jean Renoir

WRITERS

Jean Renoir, Carl Koch

STARS

Nora Gregor, Marcel Dalio, Paulette Goddard, Roland Toutain, Jean Renoir

BEFORE

1937 Renoir's movie about prisoners of war in World War I, *Grand Illusion* is the first foreign-language movie to receive a Best Picture nomination at the Oscars.

1938 Renoir's adaptation of Émile Zola's novel *The Human Beast* is a huge success.

AFTER

1941 After the critical and box-office failure of *The Rules of the Game*, Renoir makes his way to Hollywood. His first US movie is *Swamp Water*.

The *Rules of the Game* (*La Règle du jeu*) is a biting satire about the French upper classes on the brink of World War II, who are endlessly frivolous despite, or perhaps because of, the impending conflict.

At the time of its release in 1939, *The Rules of the Game* was an expensive flop, shunned by the public and critics alike—in part because of its contrast to director Jean Renoir's previous movie, *Grand Illusion* (1937), a reflection

on humanity's triumph over class. At its premiere on July 7, 1939, the audience booed. In October that year, the authorities banned the movie, as "depressing, morbid, immoral... an undesirable influence over the young."

Rediscovering the movie

During the war, the original negatives of the movie were thought to have been destroyed in a bombing raid. In the

The poacher

Marceau (Julien Carette, left) is offered a job by Robert (Marcel Dalio) to help him catch rabbits.

